

INTO THE PAST (Clockwise from far left) Artworks by K.H. Ara, Anjolie Ela Menon and V.S. Gaitonde; (bottom) a sculpture of the Air India Maharaja

temples in a pastiche of colonial painters; while P.N. Deoghare's 'Gowalia Tank' transports us to the busy bylanes of old-world Bombay.

There's a sense of the rural in the alcove that houses B. Prabha's 'Shepherd Girl' (1963), S. Yousuf Ali's 'Oh! Blessed Land' (1980), and Kanchan Chander's 'Eternal Race' (1994) triptych, but there's also an urban sophistication to Anjolie Ela Menon's 'Nawab' and 'The Pigeon' (1983), an oil painting behind a wooden window that suggests the trapped emotions of the girl in the frame. We wonder why this wasn't part of the women's section, but, going by the birds on batik and the sculpture, perhaps the curators thought it fit better into the avian theme. After all, not everything can be neatly pigeon-holed!

Like Mario Miranda's tongue-in-cheek cartoons of urban life. Or Avinash Godbole's depictions of the moustached Maharaja manifesting through various Indian ragas. These quirky works line the way up to the top gallery, where you're greeted by music and festivity via painting and sculpture. If you're wondering whether it's worth your while to climb up all the way to this slightly musty yet grand space under the NGMA dome, it most definitely is. Also because this is also where you can get a look at the extraordinary ashtray created especially for Air India by Spanish surrealist artist Salvador Dalí! Certainly something that both the Maharaja and Dalí could twirl their moustaches about...with swans, elephants and serpents as inspiration, and paid for with a baby elephant, the ashtray is as much a part of the very Indian treasure as the rest of the collection. ■

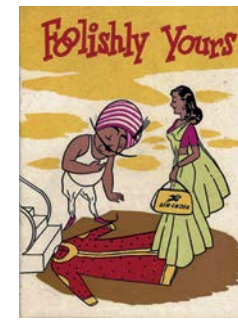
Maharaja's Treasure: Select Works of Art from the Famed Air India Collection is on view till August 13 at NGMA, Mumbai

Priya Pathiyan

ART

Treasured Trinkets

Air India's **quirky collectibles** have a devoted fan following and many are worth a king's ransom



Courtesy KAI FRIESE

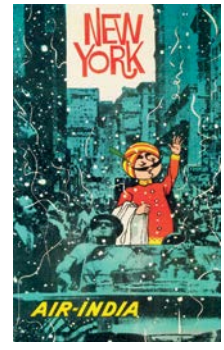
The AI collectibles There's something to be said about being India's international carrier, one whose first-class ticket was considered the epitome of one's career having taken off and status having arrived, even before the journey commenced! So many decades later, the country's antique shops and flea markets are awash with Air India nostalgia, be it valuable memorabilia like stunning scarves vibrant with celestial motifs, compilations of Indian classical music on vinyl, stylish travel bags and vanity cases, commemorative coins, or all manner of branded tchotchkes such as glass trays, calendars, passport covers, etc.

The sensational Salvador Dalí ashtrays: Air India buffs even today remember the buzz created by these ashtrays back in the late 1960s. Getting Salvador Dalí to create a one-of-a-kind objet d'art for Air India was a real coup. It's said only 500 of these curios were commissioned in 1967, to be gifted only to Air India's most prized first-class international passengers. 'Specially designed by Salvador Dalí and made by Teissonniere-Limoges for Air India' was the legend inscribed at the base of each. The one on show at the NGMA can't be handled to see its distinctive design in white, unglazed porcelain, which appears like swans one way and an elephant's head the other, with a serpent curling itself around the lip of the central shell-shaped container, but the mystique of its origins and the uniqueness of Dalí's artistry are very much in evidence.

The Kooky Kooka booklets: While other airlines have displayed a sense of humour since, the 'Foolishly Yours' pamphlets created by the irrepressible S.K. 'Bobby' Kooka (the ad man who gave us the adorable Air India Maharaja mascot and Air India its distinctively desi identity) literally wore their witticisms on their sleeve. They gave international passengers a chance to appreciate the privilege of flying and understanding the Indian psyche through their tongue-in-cheek text and comic-style illustrations. Taking liberal potshots at Mumbai weather, rich beggars, and pedantic governments, while dispensing pithy advice, they ensured a visitor to India would sail through on more than a wing and a prayer! ■

Priya Pathiyan

Photographs by INDIA PICTURE







ART IN THE AIR Air India's vintage travel posters, a postal stamp, and the sensational Salvador Dalí ashtray; (top) the cover of the in-flight reading material 'Foolishly Yours'

